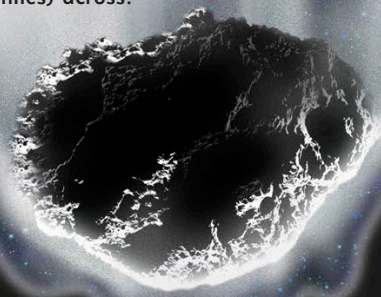


Just passing

Comets can reach tens of kilometres (miles) across.



Comets are huge, dirty space snowballs. Made of ice, rock, and dust, they hurtle through space on huge orbits around the Sun to the outer edge of our solar system.

A comet from Earth

In early 2007, the brightest comet for 40 years, comet McNaught, hit the skies. It was so bright that it could be seen during the night as well as during the day.



Distant visitor

The closest that comet Hyakutake came to the Earth was 15 million km (9.3 million miles). It was spotted in 1996 by a man in Japan who was looking through binoculars.

A comet's tail...

Halley's comet

Comets often reappear at regular intervals as they travel past the Earth. One of the most famous, Halley's comet, returns every 75 or 76 years. It is named after astronomer Edmond Halley who predicted it would return in 1758, after being sighted four times before.

Edmond Halley,
1656–1742



Halley's comet travels up to 240,000 kph (150,000 mph).